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Johnson, pope meet Chicago-style

Mayor invites Leo XIV to celebrate Mass in Grant Park next year

By Alice Yin
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

ROME — Mayor Brandon Johnson invited Pope Leo XIV to celebrate Mass in Grant Park next year during a much-awaited meeting Thursday afternoon in Vatican City, where the son of a pastor and chief executive of the pope's hometown said the two bonded over their advocacy for migrants, descendants of slavery and the city of Chicago — intricacy sports rivalries notwithstanding.

Johnson said the discussion ranged from serious matters like the federal immigration raids that have deluged the city in recent months to their differences on Chicago baseball.

“It’s a real Chicago style in terms of the way the pope delivers his message and justice,” the mayor told reporters after leaving the Vatican around 5 p.m. “What I witnessed was an incredibly humble individual whose roots really defined his leadership in this moment ... A pope who can talk about global international population shift and could have a good home Chicago argument over the Cubs and the Sox, that’s who we are in Chicago.”

Sporting a black suit adorned with a Chicago flag-themed lapel pin and cufflinks, Johnson then quipped, “Chicagoans, we can — I don’t know if this is a real word ... but we can pontiff-y anything. It is now.”

Last year’s papal election of Leo as the first American-born pontiff was received with tectonic fanfare in Chicago, a heavily Catholic city where in many neighborhoods residents often first ask one another to which parish they belong. Leo’s roots as a White Sox fan and condemnation of the U.S.’ recent mass deportations amplified the local devotion.

On Thursday, Leo made clear that he is following current affairs in his hometown, Johnson said. His first question to the mayor was, “How is Chicago?”

“I will say that he is certainly conscious of the energy that he has



Mayor Brandon Johnson hugs Ald. Lamont Robinson, 4th, at the American University of Rome after meeting with Pope Leo XIV at the Vatican on Thursday. Flanking them are Ald. Julia Ramirez, 12th, and Ald. Jason Ervin, 28th. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

See **MEETING** on Page A6



Mather High School senior Ricardo Hernández-Navarrete flashes a smile as he walks on stage before receiving his diploma during his graduation ceremony at Loyola University Chicago on Thursday. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

‘This community stands in solidarity with you today’

After 2 months in ICE detention, CPS senior free to walk Mather High graduation with classmates

By Gregory Royal Pratt
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Sitting in a Kentucky jail holding detained immigrants, more than 300 miles from home, Ricardo Hernandez-Navarrete sometimes lost hope.

Hope that he would return to Rogers Park, where the 18-year-old Colombia-born Chicago Public Schools student lives with his mother and older brother.

Hope that he would once again run up and down the soccer pitch with his classmates, scoring goals

and stopping the opponent’s attacks.

Hope that he would graduate from Mather High School and continue his education in pursuit of a better life than the one he and his family left in South America.

But no matter how dark it got in his cell, no matter how much hope had vanished, Ricardo told the Tribune he never lost faith that he would be back in Chicago.

“For some people, it would be impossible, but everything is possible if you believe in God,” Ricardo said.

On Thursday, his faith was rewarded when he walked across the stage at Loyola’s Gentile Arena and Mather principal Gary Tesinsky shook his hand.

As Ricardo filed in alongside the graduating class of 2026, families cheered their children as they marked one of modern life’s milestones. His mother, Martha Lili-ana Navarrete, sat in the front row with her older son Steven, family friend Kristy Morrow and Ricardo’s soccer coach, Costel Serban. She smiled and waved enthusiastically at Ricardo.

In remarks from the stage, Leadership Greater Chicago CEO Myetie Hamilton praised the students, many of whom are first-generation, and gave a personal shoutout to Ricardo and his family and a broader message to the graduates.

“I want you to know that this community stands in solidarity with you today for the right of humanity, of our immigrant families. Graduates, you are entering a world where your voices matter

See **GRADUATE** on Page A5

Ill. set to OK regulatory framework for AI firms

Legislation would require independent audits of safety practices

By Jeremy Gorner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

SPRINGFIELD — Gov. JB Pritzker says he intends to sign legislation that would give Illinois a regulatory framework for artificial intelligence developers after a measure sailed through the General Assembly with overwhelming bipartisan support and the backing of AI companies.

The bill, which passed 110-0 in the House on Wednesday and 52-5 in the Senate last week, would make Illinois the first state to require independent, third-party audits of the safety practices of large frontier artificial intelligence developers.

The measure is part of a broader package of bills being pushed by the Democratic-controlled General Assembly to fill what lawmakers view as a void left by federal inaction on AI regulation. The chief Senate sponsor, Democratic state Sen. Mary Edly-Allen of Grayslake, said earlier this month that without guardrails, the industry resembles “the Wild Wild West.”

“Illinois needs to create a road map for responsible innovation to prevent catastrophic risks,” she said.

State Rep. Daniel Didech, a Democrat from Buffalo Grove and the bill’s main House sponsor, said during discussion of the legislation on the House floor that AI is “among the most significant technological developments of modern time.”

“It has the potential to drastically improve the quality of life of people throughout the world but only if deployed and developed responsibly,” Didech said. “This is an important bill to move us towards that world.”

The legislation that cleared the House Wednesday would require large AI developers — those with more than \$500 million in annual gross revenue — to publish expla-

See **AI** on Page A5

INSIDE

US and Iran trade attacks, target bases

Even as the two nations traded attacks, a U.S. official said negotiators had reached agreement to extend the ceasefire. **Nation & World, Page B4**

Sox stay aggressive in win over Twins

 Davis Martin was in control all day, allowing one run in six innings during a 6-2 victory. **Sports**



U.S. Attorney Andrew Boutros sits at the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse on April 3. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Boutros to lead inquiry into group that assisted Carroll

Nonprofit helped fund some legal costs for woman who sued Trump

By Jason Meisner
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The U.S. attorney in Chicago has been tasked by the Justice Department with leading a criminal investigation into a Chicago-based nonprofit that helped fund some legal costs for E. Jean Carroll, the advice columnist who successfully sued President

Donald Trump for sexual assault and defamation, a source with knowledge of the probe confirmed to the Tribune.

The investigation began earlier this year, and no criminal charges are imminent, the source said.

The focus of the probe has been spending by American Future Republic, a left-of-center, tax-exempt organization founded in 2019 by billionaire LinkedIn co-founder Reid Hoffman, according to the source.

See **INQUIRY** on Page A2

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WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY  **H:** 82 **L:** 58
SAT.  **H:** 70 **L:** 54
SUN.  **H:** 74 **L:** 53
Complete details on Page B8

INDEX

Almanac A10
Comics D6-D7
Crossword D7
Editorials A8
Horoscope D6
Nation & World B4
Obituaries A10
Sudoku D7
Television D5

178th year No. 149
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